

Knowing Before It Hurts

A concept note on real-time organisational health diagnostics and alert governance

Real-time Diagnostic & Alerting on overall Organisation's Health — a continuous cross-function intelligence system that detects emerging conditions before they become visible in conventional reporting, and ensures every detected condition reaches a named responsible person for timely action.

1. THE INFORMATION GAP

Organisations already monitor their functions — finance, delivery, people, clients, compliance, technology, market position. Reports exist. Dashboards exist. Periodic reviews happen. The data is present.

What is absent is the following:

- 1 Function-level performance signals that are deteriorating gradually reach the CEO late — filtered through layers of reporting, below the threshold that triggers a formal alert, and visible only once they have crossed into crisis territory.
- 2 Signals from different functions that share a common cause are treated as separate departmental problems. The CEO responds to symptoms across several departments, without knowing they are one condition.
- 3 When an alert does reach the CEO, governance may not be structured — no named owner, no response deadline, no reminder if the deadline passes, no automatic escalation if action is not taken. The alert is noted. Records may not show what action was taken.

A problem sensed early is a conversation. The same problem sensed late is a crisis. The difference is almost always a gap in what the organisation could see about itself — and when.

2. WHAT ORGANISATIONAL HEALTH DIAGNOSTICS DOES DIFFERENTLY

Continuous sensing across all functions simultaneously. Each function is sensed at a cadence matched to how quickly it can deteriorate. Gradual drift that would not trigger any individual department's alert is detected as anomaly against the organisation's own rolling baseline.

Cross-function pattern recognition. When signals from two or more functions are moving together in a way that indicates a single underlying condition, the system identifies this as a named correlation pattern — one diagnosis, not multiple separate alerts. This is the capability no existing tool provides.

Structured alert governance. Every alert is routed to a named responsible person with a defined response window. Reminders are issued automatically. If the window passes without confirmed action, escalation to the next authority happens without manual intervention.

3. TWO CAPABILITIES NO CONVENTIONAL TOOL PROVIDES

CROSS-FUNCTION PATTERN DETECTION	LEAD TIME ADVANTAGE
Every existing monitoring tool — dashboards, ERPs, HR platforms, CRMs — operates on individual functions. None of them detects whether signals from different functions are connected. The diagnostic engine maintains named correlation rules. When a combination of signals matches a named pattern across functions, the system issues a single diagnosis — one named pattern, one named owner, one response. Not four departmental alerts for the same underlying condition.	Essential Function deterioration produces Critical Function consequences within 4 to 12 weeks. Diagnostics at the Essential Function tier means the CEO receives an alert when the problem is still a developing condition — not after it has produced a result. A culture deterioration that will surface as attrition in 8 weeks is visible now. A process quality decline that will produce a delivery failure in 5 weeks is visible now. The conventional equivalent appears only when the consequence has already arrived.

4. THE DIAGNOSTIC ARCHITECTURE — FOUR TIERS OF ORGANISATIONAL FUNCTIONS

The organisation's functions are grouped into four tiers. Each tier reflects a distinct mechanism by which organisational health is produced, sustained, degraded, or restored. Signals from all four tiers feed the diagnostic engine simultaneously.

Sensing cycles and response windows below are indicative. Both are calibrated and agreed with the organisation before deployment.

	TIER	FUNCTIONS MONITORED	SENSING CYCLE	RESPONSE WINDOW
1	Critical Functions <i>Signals from connected operational systems and tools</i>	Financial Health Leadership Effectiveness People & Capability Delivery & Operations Compliance & Risk Technology & Infrastructure Revenue & Market Health	Continuous and weekly	4 hours (Red) 72 hours (Amber)
2	Essential Functions <i>Signals from operational systems and weekly sensing questions</i>	Culture & Psychological Safety Employee Engagement Learning & Knowledge Management Stakeholder Relationships Strategic Alignment & Agility Information Flow & Communication Financial Sustainability	Weekly	72 hours (Amber)
3	Foundation Functions <i>Signals picked up through short curated questions at appropriate activity moments</i>	Brand & Reputation Knowledge Architecture & Dependency Physical Infrastructure & Environment Supply Chain Integrity	Monthly	2 to 4 weeks
4	Resilience Functions <i>Signals picked up through short curated questions at appropriate activity moments</i>	Innovation Pipeline Ecosystem & Partnership Health CSR & Social Licence Financial Scenario Resilience	Quarterly	1 to 3 months

5. THE ALERT AND ESCALATION MECHANISM

Every alert is a governance event — not a dashboard notification. It has a named owner, a response window, automatic reminders, and an escalation path that activates without any human decision if the window is not met.

Alert severity, response windows, and escalation paths are defined and agreed with the organisation before deployment.

Named owner	Every alert is routed to a specific named person, defined before deployment. Not a team, not a function — one person who knows they are responsible before any alert fires.
Response window	Critical Function Red: 4 hours. Essential Function Amber: 72 hours. Foundation Function: up to 4 weeks. Resilience Function: up to 3 months. The window begins at the moment the alert is issued.
Two automatic reminders	First reminder at the midpoint of the response window if no acknowledgement. Second reminder at the end of the window. Both issued automatically — no manual follow-up required.
Automatic escalation	If neither acknowledgement nor confirmed action by end of window, the alert escalates automatically to the next named authority. For Critical Function and multi-function pattern alerts, this reaches CEO level. For named systemic patterns, Board Chair is notified directly.

6. WHAT REACHES THE CEO — AND WHEN

Three channels.

CHANNEL	WHAT IT CONTAINS	WHEN
Combined Health Report	Overall Organisational Health Index across all four tiers. Function-level status. Active alerts and resolution status.	Weekly, automated.
Alert Briefing Note	Plain-language: what was detected, which functions are involved, the most likely common cause, action required, named owner, deadline.	Event-triggered — when a named cross-function pattern activates.
CEO Reflection Channel	A private named input — the CEO's own weekly responses to a small number of strategic sensing questions. Treated as named intelligence, not aggregated with other responses.	Weekly. Under 5 minutes.

7. EXPLORING A PILOT

A diagnostic pilot is the practical entry point. It requires no new operational platforms and no disruption to existing work. A preparation process precedes the pilot launch — covering system connections, sensing contexts, and alert routing. Actual piloting duration and essential resource commitments would be mutually agreed upon with the organisation.

The preparation steps, roles, and pilot phases are detailed in a separate note.

This note is a starting point for a conversation. | May 2026